

Information Letter for STEP Interventions

We are pleased to provide you with information about the **Self-Care Traumatic Episode Protocol (STEP)** intervention. This document aims to ensure that you have a clear understanding of the intervention, its structure, and its potential benefits before you decide to participate.

If you have any questions or concerns, you are encouraged to ask your STEP Intervention Provider. It is important that you feel comfortable and confident in your understanding of the intervention before moving forward.

About STEP

The STEP intervention is guided by the theories of **Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing (EMDR) Therapy** and follows the framework of the Group Traumatic Episode Protocol (G-TEP). EMDR is designed to help individuals process traumatic memories and reduce emotional distress using guided eye movements or other bilateral stimulation techniques. STEP was developed as an intervention to support mental health professionals and individuals dealing with stress and trauma.

EMDR Therapy is a therapy designed to help process traumatic memories and reduce emotional distress. It involves using eye movements or other forms of bilateral stimulation (e.g., tapping or sounds) while focusing on distressing memories. This process helps reframe negative feelings and promotes emotional healing. EMDR is an evidence-based treatment supported by research for effectively treating trauma, anxiety, depression, and PTSD.

For more information about EMDR Therapy: <https://www.emdria.org/about-emdr-therapy/>

Purpose of the Intervention

STEP provides a structured approach to help individuals manage overwhelming experiences. The process involves:

- pre-screening questionnaires to ensure the protocol is appropriate for your needs;
- an introductory video explaining EMDR Therapy, trauma, and memory processing;
- videos to guide the processing of the overwhelming memory;
- self-regulation activities for emotional stability; and
- feedback forms to reflect on progress.

Please note that the contents of this protocol are not intended as a substitute for professional medical or psychological advice, diagnosis or treatment.

Who Can Participate?

STEP is designed for individuals who feel overwhelmed by distressing events and wish to develop coping strategies. However, the protocol is **not** suitable for those experiencing:

- Suicidal thoughts
- Psychotic or dissociative disorders
- Hallucinations, delusions, or dissociation

If you are experiencing any of the above or are unsure if you are, please contact your STEP Intervention Provider for support and to discuss the next steps in your care.

Following completion of the screening measures, your STEP Intervention Provider will discuss the next steps with you. It may be recommended that you participate in STEP Solo, STEP Together, or another intervention, depending on your needs. Information about the STEP interventions is included below.

STEP Solo

The STEP Solo intervention is intended for autonomous use in self-care, to process aspects of a distressing experience or as a tool for maintenance. When granted access to the STEP Solo intervention, you will engage in self-regulation strategies, containment, and guided processing.

As you complete the STEP Solo intervention, your results will be sent via email to your STEP Intervention Provider. Throughout the process, there may be times when you are directed to self-regulation exercises. If this occurs, please reach out to your STEP Intervention Provider for support and to discuss the next steps in your care. They will assist you in finding an intervention that may better suit you and your needs.

Please be aware that the results of the STEP Solo intervention may not be monitored continuously. While your STEP Intervention Provider will guide you through the process, there may be instances when support is not immediately available. If you are experiencing distress or feel overwhelmed at any time, please reach out to the following resources for immediate support:

- emergency services Insert local information
- crisis helpline Insert local information

STEP Together

The STEP Together intervention is a group intervention designed to support participants in processing overwhelming experiences in a guided and structured manner. During these sessions, you will engage in self-regulation, containment exercises, and guided processing of your own overwhelming experience.

Please note that this group intervention is unique in its approach. You will not be asked to share specific details about your distressing experience with other group members, nor will you hear explicit details about the experiences of others. Instead, the group setting focuses on fostering a supportive environment for the processing of these experiences where participants are encouraged to share strengths, personal resources, and insights gained from the process while reviewing and processing distressing parts of their own incident or series of incidents individually within the group setting.

This structure safeguards privacy and fosters a focus on empowerment, growth, and resilience while minimizing potential distress that may result from sharing or hearing challenging personal details in a group setting.

Confidentiality in Group Settings

Confidentiality is a cornerstone of any group experience, including the STEP Together intervention. To create a safe and supportive environment where everyone feels comfortable sharing their thoughts and engaging in the process, it is crucial to respect the privacy of all group members.

Here's how you can help maintain confidentiality:

- 1. Please Keep Information Within the Group:** Anything shared during the group session must remain within the group. This includes refraining from discussing group members, their participation, or things they share in the group with friends, family, or others outside the group.
- 2. Avoid Recording or Taking Notes:** Recording of any nature and disclosure of any elements of the STEP intervention is expressly prohibited. It is expected that all participants maintain the spirit of cooperation for mutual support of other group members.
- 3. Be Mindful of Virtual Participation:** If the group intervention takes place online, ensure you are in a private, secure location where no one else can overhear the session or view your screen. Use headphones, if necessary, to maintain the privacy of others.
- 4. Report Concerns to the STEP Intervention Provider:** If you feel confidentiality has been breached or have concerns about the group dynamics, speak privately with the STEP Intervention Provider as soon as possible.

Research Participation

Ongoing research helps improve the STEP protocol. Anonymous data may be used for research and educational purposes, but participation in research is entirely voluntary. Declining research participation will not impact your ability to engage in the intervention. To opt out of the research, inform your STEP Intervention Provider, who will contact the protocol developers, Prepped 4 Learning Inc., and instruct them to delete your data.

Next Steps

If you decide to proceed, you will be asked to review and sign a Consent & Terms of Use document, which outlines your rights, responsibilities, and the conditions of participation.

You may stop using the protocol at any time. If you choose to withdraw, please inform your STEP Intervention Provider so they can support you and guide the next steps in your care.

If you have any questions, please contact

Insert STEP Intervention Provider's Name

Insert Organization

Insert Email

Insert Phone Number

We look forward to supporting you on your self-care journey.